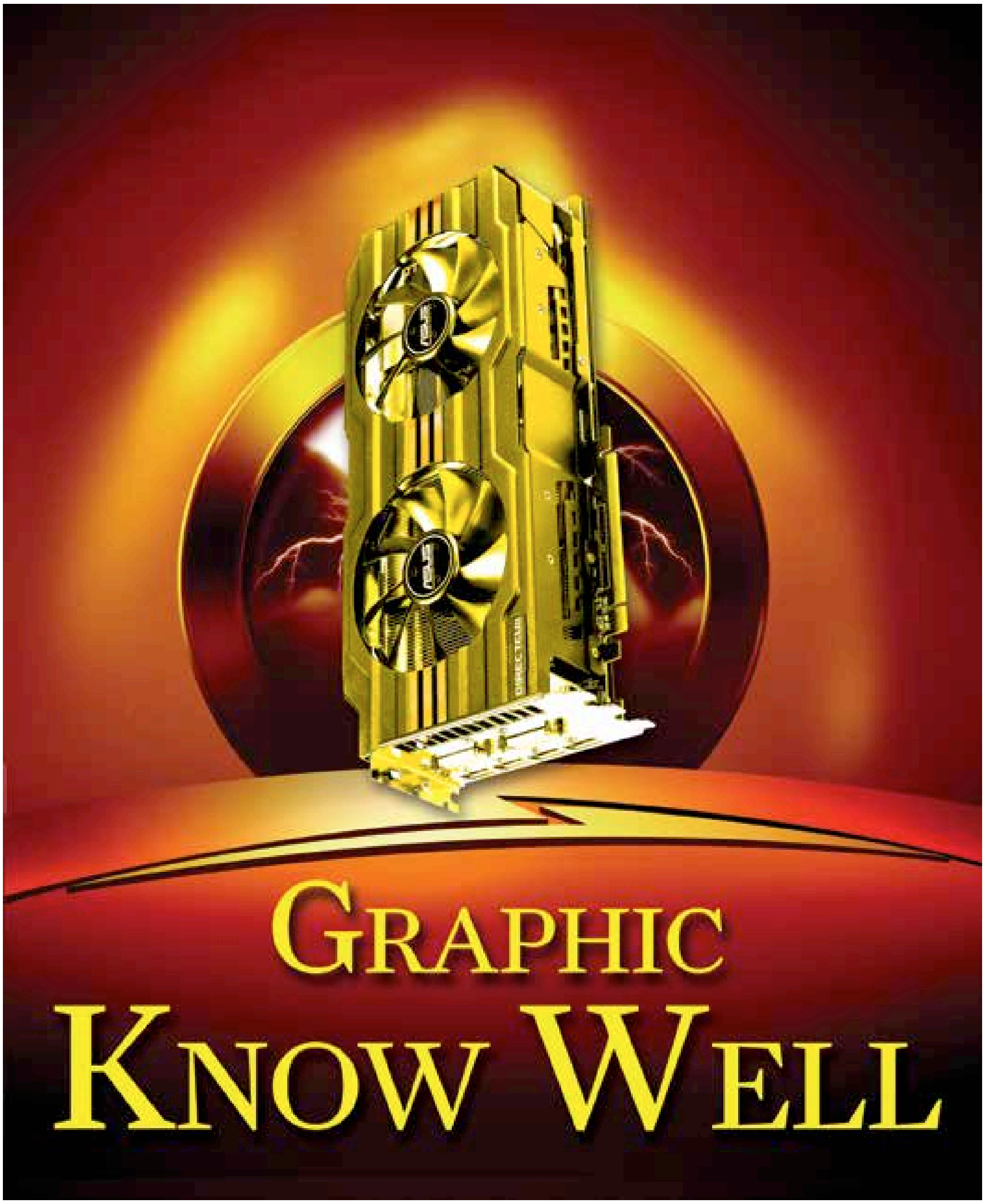

IMAGING: VIJAY PADAYA

If the budget for your next graphics card lies between ₹5,000 to ₹25,000 then we've got you covered.

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Over the last one year we've seen the NVIDIA's 600 series and AMD HD 7000 series get retired. Well not really, in the world of silicon we have the same thing shoveled to us after a simple rebadging exercise. This is to mean that the NVIDIA 600 series and AMD HD 7000 series is still around, but they now have new names with minor or negligible architectural improvements. Especially the mobile graphics hardware segment which has to make do with "ancient" technology since that space operates roughly two generations behind. The very premier laptops might have a generation old graphics chip while the rest are way behind.

On-chip graphics has also advanced quite well. Intel's latest, dubbed Iris Pro is actually quite a capable graphics chip and has a TDP of 47W. We could possibly see a little stagnation in the TDP of processors due to this fact before it continues the downward trend in processor TDP. However, discrete graphics solutions from NVIDIA and AMD are way ahead of the curve and we can now experience desktop style graphics on laptops as well. Though not all features of a full fledged GTX 760 or R9 270X can be surpassed any time soon, the new Maxwell architecture does show promise.

What's new in the graphics world?

AMD started off with a brand new architecture – Hawaii. There are only two cards which are truly based on the Hawaii chipset, viz. the R9 290 and the R9 290X. Both have been particularly well received and perform quite well. The R9 290X outperformed the GTX Titan but the GTX 780 Ti which was released around the same time didn't let AMD get away with the throne. It was a rather short victory. Along with the GCN (Graphics Core Next) architecture AMD also released information regarding Mantle, an API set to occupy the same space as DirectX. While visually there isn't much that can be said to differentiate between the two, Mantle's performance is better than DirectX since it gives direct access to the GPU memory resulting in low latency and faster calculations.

That wasn't the only change, as even the nomenclature of the cards were changed and another equally difficult to